

NEWS | IMMIGRATION

19-Year-Old Royer Perez-Jimenez Dies in ICE Jail Known for Abuse

Perez-Jimenez is at least the 49th person who has died in detention since Trump returned to office in January 2025.

By Julia Conley, COMMON DREAMS
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Protesters take to the streets in Orlando, Florida, on January 31, 2026, to demonstrate against the actions of ICE, chanting slogans and carrying signs.

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A teenager who was arrested in January after being stopped for a traffic violation in Florida is now believed to be the youngest person to have died in immigration detention under the second Trump administration, after US Immigration and Customs Enforcement notified Congress of the 19-year-old's death this week.

Royer Perez-Jimenez was found (<https://www.miaminewtimes.com/news/mexican-teen-dies-in-ice-custody-in-south-florida-40533174/>) unresponsive by a detention officer at Glades County Detention Center in Moore Haven, Florida at around 2:30 am Eastern on Monday. The center operates as an immigration detention facility under a contract with ICE.

Local emergency workers arrived and attempted lifesaving interventions, according to ICE's statement, but Perez-Jimenez was pronounced dead soon after.

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The agency said Perez-Jimenez "died of a presumed suicide," but did not detail how that was determined and noted that the cause of death is still under investigation.

According to (<https://prospect.org/2026/01/29/ice-trump-killed-injured-list-dhs-cbp-border-patrol-renee-good-alex-pretti/>), a tracker by *The American Prospect*, which has been monitoring deaths in ICE detention as well as deaths and injuries of people who have encountered federal immigration agents conducting enforcement operations, Perez-Jimenez is at least the 49th person who has died in detention since President Donald Trump took office for his second term in January 2025.

Perez-Jimenez was stopped on January 22 by the Volusia County Sheriff's Office for allegedly "crossing traffic lanes without using a crosswalk" while riding a scooter, according to the *Miami New Times*. He allegedly refused to stop and gave the officers "multiple fake names," which are both misdemeanors, according to an arrest report viewed by the *New Times*, but ICE's statement (<https://www.ice.gov/news/releases/criminal-illegal-alien-mexico-passes-away-glades-county-detention-facility>) alleges that Perez-Jimenez had been charged with "felony fraud for impersonation."

The ICE report stated that Perez-Jimenez eventually told the officers that he had “overstayed his visa and is currently in the United States illegally” after coming into the country from his native Mexico.

ICE said Perez-Jimenez initially entered the US in 2022 and was granted a “voluntary return” to Mexico after he encountered US Border Patrol agents. He then reentered the US.

While alleging Perez-Jimenez had died of a presumed suicide, ICE acknowledged that he had been evaluated by medical staff during his intake, did not report any behavioral health concerns, and answered “no” to all suicide screening questions.

A spokesperson for the agency did not respond to a question from *News Times* regarding whether the 19-year-old was on suicide watch.

In 2022, 17 members of Congress called [. \(https://www.scribd.com/document/556459160/Letter-to-Secretary-Mayorkas-Feb-2022\)](https://www.scribd.com/document/556459160/Letter-to-Secretary-Mayorkas-Feb-2022) for the closure of Glades County Detention Center over escalating reports of abuse. They said immigrants there were subjected to “racist abuse, often resulting in verbal abuse and violence; sexual abuse, including sexual voyeurism by guards who have watched women shower; life-endangering Covid-19 and medical neglect, including a near-fatal carbon monoxide leak last November; and regular exposure to highly dangerous levels of a toxic disinfectant chemical spray linked to severe medical harms and long-term damage to reproductive health.”

Black immigrants in particular also faced death threats, the use of pepper spray, solitary confinement, and “extreme forms of physical violence like using the restraint chair,” according to the lawmakers.

ICE ended its deal with the center in 2022, only for Trump to reopen [. \(https://www.cnn.com/2025/06/20/us/ice-glades-county-detention-investigation\)](https://www.cnn.com/2025/06/20/us/ice-glades-county-detention-investigation), the facility for immigration detention in 2025.

Austin Kocher, a professor at the S.I. Newhouse School of Public Communications at Syracuse University, warned [. \(https://x.com/ackocher/status/2034689866693226734\)](https://x.com/ackocher/status/2034689866693226734) that despite the accelerating rate of deaths in ICE detention, “Congress has not launched a single investigation.”

“This is not complicated or controversial. I am simply asking Congress to take seriously the death of people in ICE’s care and custody,” wrote [. \(https://austinkocher.substack.com/p/as-predicted-ice-reports-another\)](https://austinkocher.substack.com/p/as-predicted-ice-reports-another) Kocher. “ICE is an agency for which Congress is obligated to provide accountability and oversight, particularly when that agency is unable or unwilling to police itself — such as now.”

Kocher urged Americans to call on US Rep. Scott Franklin (R-Fla.), who represents the district where the facility is located, to demand an investigation.

“Light up his inboxes, phone lines, and social media until he does his job and looks into the conditions at this facility,” said Kocher. “If you’ve been waiting for the time to take direction action, wait no longer: Act now. Demand accountability. Do not stop until you get real answers.”

The 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline — which offers 24/7, free, and confidential support — can be reached by calling or texting 988, or through chat at 988lifeline.org (<https://988lifeline.org/>).

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JULIA CONLEY (<https://truthout.org/authors/julia-conley/>)

Julia Conley is a staff writer for *Common Dreams*.

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